Fifteen Minutes

By Dave de Christopher

NANCY: Welcome to "Nancy After Dark". Tonight we're talking about infidelity - who does it, who they do it to, and what about the children? Stay tuned. *[She strikes an animated pose, freezes for a few seconds.]*

INTRODUCTION

15 minutes of fame (or famous for 15 minutes) is an expression coined by American artist Andy Warhol. It refers to the fleeting condition of celebrity which then passes to some new object as soon as the public's attention span is exhausted. Like it or not; consumed by the craze of struggling to avoid it . . . In today's world, reality TV is the hottest thing going. But have we gone too far by showcasing vulnerable people so we can "catch them in the act" and "scold" them publicly? Dave de Christopher takes the current Reality TV phenomenon one step further in his play Fifteen Minutes.

ANTHONY: What? What are you doing? *[**ANTHONY:** turns on lamp on his bedside table. Stage lights come up full. Person in downstage corner is a woman in a pink jogging suit, hereafter known as AUDIENCE.]*

NANCY: Shhhh! Okay, we're clear. *[She begins stretching her mouth in various directions, then rattles off some tongue twisters.]* Red leather, yellow leather, red leather, yellow leather, red leath

ANTHONY: *[Still groggy.]* What are you doing?

NANCY: My lip-loosening exercises. I need to improve my diction if I want to go national.

ANTHONY: National what?

NANCY: Only syndicated, not network. But the Viacom guy is supposed to come to the show on Thursday, then take a meeting with me.

ANTHONY: What show?

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NANCY: Go back to sleep, Tony. My talk show "Nancy After Dark".

ANTHONY: You ... pfffft ... you don't have a talk show.

NANCY: *[With patronizing patience.]* Practically everybody has a talk show nowadays. There are five in the neighborhood already.

ANTHONY: This has got to be a dream ...

NANCY: *[Sharply.]* Yes, it's a dream, go back to sleep. We're coming out of commercial soon, so you'll either have to be quiet or pull the covers over your head and pretend you're sleeping. You're good at that, aren't you?

ANTHONY: How can I sleep with all this talking, and with that [person] watching and with the lights on?

NANCY: Look, this is our twenty-third show in the new time slot, and it's the very first time you woke up, so you tell me. *[Pause.]*

ANTHONY: I don't believe you. SO where's the camera?

NANCY: It's hidden. *[Gesturing.]* In the right eye of... that red-headed girl ...in the sad eyes painting

ANTHONY: No ... no, it's not. Why am I arguing with you?

NANCY: Alright, it's not. Go back to sleep, Tony.

ANTHONY: Did you ... *[Getting a sudden idea.]* Is this supposed to spice up our sex life?

NANCY: No, but if you have an idea for a show, you can call and leave a message at 1-800-GO- NANCY. *[Strikes a pose. To AUDIENCE.]* We're back ... talking about infidelity.

ANTHONY: Infidelity?

NANCY: That's Tony, my husband. *[With an artificial laugh.]* Ha, ha, go back to sleep, honey. Our first guest is no stranger to infidelity. Meet Libby. *[Warmly.]* Welcome to my world.

LIBBY: Thank you, Nancy.

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NANCY: *[Gentle voice.]* So. Tell us what happened.

LIBBY: 'Kay. He was my boss ... *[She sniffs.]* ... At the plant ... *[She sniffs.]* And he'd say nice stuff about my hair and my clothes.

NANCY: That's how it started?

LIBBY: That ... *[Eager to fall in with NANCY's scenario.]* ... Yeah! Yeah, that's how it started, Nancy. That's how it started.

NANCY: *[Taking her hand.]* Go on, please.

LIBBY: And one thing led to another.

NANCY: *[Suddenly sassy]* No, no, girlfriend. I don't think so. *[Warm again.]* We're trying to feel your pain, so be specific.

LIBBY: Well ... he went from complimenting my clothes and my hair to complimenting my body.

NANCY: *[Pretending not to understand.]* Your body? Well what did he say?

LIBBY: He said ... *[She sniffs.]* ... "Nice rack." Nancy, which part is the rack?

NANCY: SO he complimented you and you had sex with him?

LIBBY: Yes. No! hat's just how it started. I was trying to explain what he's like.

NANCY: You're leaving something out though, aren't you, Libby? *[Pause.]* He's married, isn't he?

LIBBY: Yes. But it wasn't like that. I didn't know he was married.

NANCY: He never told you ...?

LIBBY: He didn't wear a ring.

NANCY: We're coming up to a break, so cut to the chase.

LIBBY: He blackmailed me.

NANCY: Really? Wow! How?

LIBBY: He said he'd fire me if I didn't ... submit to him.

NANCY: He wanted you to give it up.

LIBBY: Yeah, he wanted me ... He made me give it up, Nancy!

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NANCY: Audience, would you like to meet this guy? Well we will, right after this break. *[NANCY strikes a pose and holds it for several seconds.]* Okay we're clear.

LIBBY: Nancy, I just want to say thank you

NANCY: I'm sorry I'm not allowed to talk to you during the break; it takes the spontaneity out of the interview, *[Quietly.]* What a to-do to die today at a minute or two to two. A thing distinctly hard to say but harder still to do. For they'll beat a tattoo - of course*... [She strikes a pose.]* ... at twenty to two '" Doctor, you're on deck!! Okay, we're back in five ... *[She strikes a pose.]* ... four ...three *... [She mouths "two, one."]* ... We're back with Libby. Libby has spent some time with our resident therapist and now feels ready to confront the married boss that she had an affair with. Isn't that right, Libby?

LIBBY: Yes, Nancy.

NANCY: Well, I've got a surprise for everybody! *[She hits **ANTHONY:**.]* Wake up! *[**ANTHONY:** bolts up in bed. LIBBY gasps.]*

ANTHONY: What!? *[His eyes are barely open.]*

LIBBY: *[A sad wail.]* Tony...

NANCY: SO now you recognize him?

ANTHONY: *[He turns on bedside lamp. Lights come up full.]* Elizabeth? What are you doing here?

LIBBY: *[To NANCY.]* I didn't really look at him before. I was talking to you.

NANCY: *[To AUDIENCE, instantly plaintive.]* Yes, it's true. Tony is the one. Tony is the adulterer. I am sharing my pain.

ANTHONY: How could you do this?

NANCY: It's sweeps week. We need to get high ratings.

ANTHONY: How could you do this to me?

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NANCY: *[Boldly.]* I'm doing it to me, too. My life is an open book. *[Pause.]* Confession is good for the soul.

ANTHONY: Maybe it's time to get it out in the open.

NANCY: Air our dirty laundry.

LIBBY: Get ... get it off our chests.

NANCY: *[Seriously.]* So, Libby, let's first get straight, Tony calls you ... Elizabeth?

LIBBY: It's my professional name.

NANCY: I thought it was your slut name. I'm sorry. I don't know what's happening to me. My talk show host self is warring with my talk show guest self, and I feel very volatile ... *[Turning to AUDIENCE.]* ... and you're seeing it live on tape. Libby, is there anything you'd like to say to Tony?

LIBBY: Why did you lie? I feel so guilty, dirty, cheap ...

NANCY: We can all understand that.

LIBBY: Why? *[She sniffs]* Why?

NANCY: Tony... why?

ANTHONY: *[As if it's an amazing phenomenon.]* I don't know... we were drawn together ...

NANCY: It just happened.

LIBBY: But why? Not how, Tony? Why?

NANCY: Good question, Libby. And we'll answer it right after this break. *[NANCY strikes a pose, holding it for five seconds. LIBBY stares at the floor. **ANTHONY:** considers his options.]* We're clear. *[Calling offstage.]* Doctor, get ready!

DR. BLEDSOE: *[Off]* I have counted the tiles on your shower wall four times! Just introduce me, and don't forget my hyphen.

NANCY: QUIET! *[She strikes a pose.]* We're back in five, four, three ... *[She mouths "Two, one.'1* ... We're back. I couldn't get Libby and Tony to talk

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during the break, but maybe our resident therapist can help. Please welcome Doctor Allegra Shayne-Bledsoe. Welcome to my world.

DR. BLEDSOE: Thank you, Nancy. I'm feeling a lot of tension in this room.

NANCY: Anger, yes, I can feel it too.

DR. BLEDSOE: No, I think it's sexual tension, Nancy. *[She sits and takes **ANTHONY:**'s hand.]* Tony... may I call you Tony?

ANTHONY: Yes.

NANCY: There are a few other things I'd like to call you.

DR. BLEDSOE: *[Sharply.]* Please, I'm trying to work here!! *[to **ANTHONY:**.]* Tony, what do you want?

ANTHONY: A good night's sleep?

DR. BLEDSOE: Humor is a very common defense mechanism.

ANTHONY: All right. I'd like to put this behind me ...And get on with my life.

DR. BLEDSOE: Good work, Tony. That's a very healthy need. But I think that's up to Libby and Nancy. Gals, what do you think? Libby? Do you think you can put this behind you?

LIBBY: I guess so. But what about our baby? *[Crying.]* What about little Toni?

DR. BLEDSOE: You and Tony have a son?

LIBBY: A daughter; Toni with an "i" ya know? She needs her daddy. Tony hasn't seen her in four months, and he hasn't sent us any money in almost a year.

DR. BLEDSOE: How old is little Toni with an "i"?

LIBBY: She'll be two in October.

DR. BLEDSOE: SO Nancy... what are you feeling now?

NANCY: *[To DR. BLEDSOE.]* I'm not sure. *[To LIBBY.]* Haven't you ever heard of adoption? *[To DR. BLEDSOE.]* I don't think I'm in touch with my feelings. *[To LIBBY.]* Haven't you ever heard of birth control? *[To DR. BLEDSOE.]*

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No wait... something's coming. *[To LIBBY.]* Haven't you ever heard of self-control? *[To DR. BLEDSOE.]* I feel bad ... angry ... powerless ...

DR. BLEDSOE: And what do you want to do?

NANCY: I'd like to kill her ... *[This is a guilty pleasure.]* ... I think. Is that wrong?

DR. BLEDSOE: Feelings are not right or wrong. They just are.

NANCY: Well, I do. I feel like killing her ... Doctor? Men stray... And I think Tony and I have a chance to heal our wounds. Don't you, Tony?

ANTHONY: Absolutely.

NANCY: So thank you for your feedback, but I'm going to be sticking with Tony, and focusing my revenge on Libby.

DR. BLEDSOE: Good work, Nancy. In the words of Stephen Sondheim, the choice may have been mistaken, but the choosing was not.

NANCY: And unfortunately we're out of time. SO I guess we'll all have to wait until tomorrow to find out what that revenge is.

DR. BLEDSOE: Well, it is sweeps week.

NANCY: Libby, can you come back tomorrow?

LIBBY: I can't come back tomorrow. I'm a guest on "Desiree 'Til Dawn" down the street. My husband is a cross-dressing priest.

NANCY: All right, all right. Let's compromise. *[NANCY opens drawer of night table, pulls out black glove and puts it on quickly.]* A perfect fit! *[NANCY pulls knife from drawer and stabs LIBBY in shoulder. LIBBY screams.]* Stop being such a baby it's just a flesh wound. *[To AUDIENCE.]* Thanks for coming into my world. I hope you'll visit "Nancy After Dark" tomorrow. Sleep tight. *[NANCY strikes a pose]*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier – HI
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